A FIELD GUIDE

DEBUNKED

PART 2 OF 11

Flying Machines
and Ancient Tech

by LOVEPREET SINGH

The Vaimanika Shastra. Talpade's 1895 plane. Pushpak Vimana. The Mahabharata "internet". Sanjay's "live TV". And the rest of the flying claims. Ten chapters. Ten debunks. One method.

FOREWORD

A Note Before We Continue

In Part 1 we built the toolkit. The 6 step debunk. The 10 logical tricks. The difference between Hindu and Hindutva. The crash course on what science actually is. If you have not read Part 1, you can still read this one, but I will keep referencing the toolkit, so you might want to flip back when something gets confusing.

Now we start using the tool. This whole part is about flying claims. Ten of them. Vimanas, the Vaimanika Shastra, Talpade's 1895 plane, Pushpak, Sanjay's "live TV", the Mahabharata "internet", Narada the "satellite", ancient robots, ancient self driving chariots, interplanetary travel. All ten run through the same six step pattern.

One thing to flag upfront. The single most important chapter in this whole part is Chapter 1, on the Vaimanika Shastra. Almost every other vimana story you have ever heard traces back to that one text. Once you understand where that text came from and what it actually says, half the work is done. The other nine chapters fall like dominoes.

I will be sharp. I will mock the claims. I will not mock the gods, the scriptures, or your family. The target is the lie. Not the lamp.

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Lovepreet Singh
2026

CONTENTS OF PART 2

Ten Flying Claims

Every chapter uses the same 6 step structure you learned in Part 1. The Claim. Where It Came From. What the Text Actually Says. The Real Science. The Debunk. The Honest Picture.

"Geometrically, aerodynamically and aeronautically, none of the planes shown by Subba Raya Shastry have any possibility of flying."
H.S. Mukunda and colleagues, Indian Institute of Science Bangalore, in Scientific Opinion, 1974

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If the source text is fake, every claim built on it is fake too. That is the whole game.

CHAPTER 01

The Vaimanika Shastra. Where Almost Every Vimana Story Comes From

> The Claim Ancient India had a detailed engineering manual for flying machines, called the *Vaimanika Shastra* (or *Vymanika Shastra*). It was written by the sage Maharishi Bharadwaja thousands of years ago. It describes vimanas with mercury engines, sun powered propulsion, anti lightning shields, and 32 secret pilot techniques. NASA has supposedly studied it.

Where It Came From

Brace yourself for the cleanest debunk in this whole book.

The Vaimanika Shastra is **not** ancient. It was not found in any temple. No copy of it exists from before the 20th century. It was dictated between roughly 1900 and 1922 CE by a man named **Pandit Subbaraya Shastry** (1866 to 1940), who lived in Anekal, near Bengaluru.

Subbaraya Shastry was not lying exactly. He claimed to be in a meditative trance, and that the ancient sage Maharishi Bharadwaja was dictating the text to him in real time. So in his mind, he was a channel, not an author. His scribe wrote down what he said. The pages sat in private hands for decades.

In 1952, twelve years after Shastry's death, a man named **G.R. Josyer** got hold of the manuscript and published it through something he called the "International Academy of Sanskrit Research" in Mysore. An English translation followed in 1973. The cover claimed the text was from the ancient sage. The press release said NASA was studying it. The story took off.

Today, almost every Indian school textbook and political speech that mentions "ancient flying machines" is, knowingly or not, sourcing from this one book. A book whose origin is fully documented as a 1900 to 1922 CE trance dictation by a man in a Bengaluru village.

What the "Original" Text Actually Says

This is the funniest part. The Vaimanika Shastra describes:

- Four kinds of vimanas. Rukma, Sundara, Tripura, and Shakuna.
- 32 "secrets" the pilot must know. Including how to make the vimana invisible, how to make it shrink, how to hear conversations on enemy planes, how to project images, and how to paralyse enemies with poison fumes.
- Mercury based engines. Specifically a "mercury vortex engine" that creates lift through circulation of mercury vapour.
- Pilot diets. The vimana pilot is supposed to eat specific foods and avoid others.
- Special alloys with names like *somaka*, *soundalika*, and *mourthwika*. The recipes for these alloys are given in detail. None of them exist or can be made.
- Detailed mechanical diagrams. (We will come to these in a second.)

The text reads exactly like what it is: a 20th century Indian's idea of what an ancient flying machine should sound like. Mercury was chosen because it is a heavy, mysterious metal. Sun power was added because the sun is impressive. Invisibility and poison fumes were added because they sound powerful in stories.

The Real Science

A flying machine is not magic. It is a balance of four forces.

DEFINE: THE FOUR FORCES OF FLIGHT **Lift** (the upward push, usually from air flowing over a wing). **Weight** (gravity pulling the aircraft down). **Thrust** (forward force from an engine). **Drag** (air resistance pushing back). For an aircraft to fly, lift has to equal or beat weight, and thrust has to beat drag. That's it. If your design does not produce lift, you cannot fly. Mercury vapour does not produce lift. Solar rays do not produce useful thrust at the scale needed to lift a person.

The wings of an aircraft work because of a specific shape called an aerofoil. Air moving over the curved upper surface goes faster than air going under the flat lower surface. Faster moving air has lower pressure. The pressure difference creates lift. This is high school physics. It was understood and written down by Daniel Bernoulli in 1738 and refined into a full theory of flight by people like Otto Lilienthal in the 1890s and the Wright brothers in 1903.

None of the four forces are described in the Vaimanika Shastra. The word "lift" is not in there. The concept of an aerofoil is not in there. There is no description of how the vimana's mass is balanced against any upward force. The "engine" is a vague description of mercury sloshing in pots.

The Debunk

In 1974, five scientists at the Indian Institute of Science in Bangalore, the country's most prestigious engineering school, did the obvious thing. They took the Vaimanika Shastra seriously enough to engineer it. They were H.S. Mukunda, S.M. Deshpande, H.R. Nagendra, A. Prabhu, and S.P. Govindaraju. Real scientists. Aerospace and propulsion engineers. They published their findings in a journal called *Scientific Opinion* in 1974, in a paper titled "A critical study of the work 'Vyamanika Shastra'." This paper exists. You can read it.

What did they conclude? Five things.

1. **The geometry of the aircraft is impossible.** The wings have aspect ratios (the ratio of wingspan to chord, basically how long versus how wide) that would never produce lift. One of the designs has a body so squat and stubby that it could not even glide.
2. **The propulsion system is nonsense.** Mercury based engines, as described, violate basic thermodynamics. You cannot get useful thrust by heating mercury in pots, no matter how cleverly you spin them.
3. **The alloys are fictional.** The recipes given do not produce metals. The chemistry does not work.
4. **The mechanical diagrams are decorative, not functional.** They look impressive on a page. None of them describe a working machine.
5. **And the killer.** No copy of the text exists from before 1900. There is no manuscript in any old palm leaf collection, no quotation in any pre 1900 Sanskrit commentary, no reference in any pre 1900 Indian library catalogue. The "ancient" text has no ancient existence.

The Mukunda paper's actual concluding line, which is now famous in Indian aerospace circles: *"None of the planes have properties or capabilities of being flown. The drawings definitely point to a knowledge of modern machinery on the part of the author."*

Read that last sentence again. A 1974 engineering team, studying a supposedly ancient text, concluded that the author knew about modern machinery. That is because the author lived from 1866 to 1940.

The "NASA Is Studying It" Lie

You will see this claim everywhere. "NASA scientist confirmed the Vaimanika Shastra." Let us be specific. The original "NASA" claim seems to trace back to G.R. Josyer's own 1973 English translation, where the introduction makes vague gestures at American scientific interest. There is no NASA paper. No NASA scientist named in connection with the text. No reference in any NASA publication. When you search NASA's online catalogue for the Vaimanika Shastra, you get nothing. The claim was invented by the man selling the book.

The Honest Picture

Here is what India actually achieved in flight and aerospace.

- **JRD Tata** flew India's first commercial flight in October 1932, from Karachi to Bombay via Ahmedabad. He flew the plane himself. Tata Airlines became Air India.
- The **Indian Air Force** was founded in 1932 and has flown combat operations in WWII and in every Indian war since 1947.
- **HAL**, Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, has designed and built Indian aircraft including the HF-24 Marut (the first Indian jet fighter, 1961) and the Tejas (current Indian light combat aircraft).
- **ISRO**, the Indian Space Research Organisation, has launched satellites to Mars (Mangalyaan, 2014) and the Moon (Chandrayaan series, including Chandrayaan 3's south pole landing in 2023).

These are real Indian achievements, in real Indian aerospace, with real Indian engineers, who used real physics. They did not need the Vaimanika Shastra. They worked, because they were built on the actual four forces of flight that the Vaimanika Shastra does not even mention.

If you want to take pride in Indian aviation, take pride in JRD Tata. Take pride in Mangalyaan. Don't take pride in a 1900s village mystic's trance writings sold by a man in 1952 with a fake academy.

Test Yourself

1. When was the Vaimanika Shastra actually written down?
2. Name two of the five problems the 1974 IISc team found with it.
3. Has NASA ever published anything about the Vaimanika Shastra?

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CHAPTER 02

Pushpak Vimana. The Flying Chariot of the Ramayana

> The Claim The Pushpak Vimana of the Ramayana proves ancient India had real flying machines. It belonged to Kubera, was stolen by Ravana, and was used by Lord Rama to fly back from Lanka to Ayodhya. It is described in detail in the Ramayana, so it must have been real technology.

Where It Came From

The Pushpak Vimana is from the **Valmiki Ramayana**, an ancient Sanskrit epic. The Ramayana was composed orally over centuries, and the version we have today was put together roughly between 500 BCE and 100 CE. It is genuinely ancient. That part is not in dispute.

What is in dispute is what the text actually says about Pushpak, and whether what it says counts as "real technology."

What the Original Text Actually Says

The Ramayana describes Pushpak in two main contexts. The **Uttara Kanda** tells how the chariot was originally given by Brahma to Kubera, the god of wealth. Ravana, Kubera's half brother, took it by force. After Ravana's defeat, Lord Rama used it to fly back from Lanka to Ayodhya with Sita and Lakshmana. The journey is described in the **Yuddha Kanda**.

Here is what the actual text says about how it works.

- It moves **by the will of the owner**. You think about going somewhere and it goes there.
- It **changes size** based on need. It can hold one person or thousands.
- It is **made of gold** and decorated with jewels.
- It **moves without engines**, without wings, without fuel, and without any described mechanism.
- It can fly to any of the worlds, including the heavenly realms of the gods.

Robert Goldman, the Princeton Sanskrit scholar who led the multi volume English translation of the Valmiki Ramayana, makes a clear point in his commentary. Pushpak is described as a **magical** object, a divine gift, in the same way that Indra's thunderbolt or Vishnu's discus are magical. It is not described as a machine. It is described as a marvel.

> *"The Pushpaka vimana of Kubera is a divine flying chariot, supernatural in origin and operation, more closely related to the mythical chariots of the gods in the Vedic and Puranic traditions than to any mechanical artifact." Robert P. Goldman, The Ramayana of Valmiki, Princeton University Press, Volume 1 (1984), introduction.*

The Real Science

We covered this in Chapter 1. To fly, you need lift, thrust, and a way to balance weight and drag. The Pushpak description provides none of these.

Modern aircraft, helicopters, drones, and rockets all use specific physical principles. Aerofoils for fixed wing aircraft. Rotor blades for helicopters. Reaction thrust for rockets. The Pushpak operates by **mental command**, which is not a physical principle that exists anywhere in nature.

The Debunk

The Pushpak Vimana is a beautiful piece of literature. It is not engineering.

1. **Mental control is not a propulsion system.** If a vehicle moves because you think about moving, that is magic. By that standard, the magic carpet from *One Thousand and One Nights* is also "ancient flying machine evidence" and we should be teaching Persian aviation history.
2. **"Changes size" is not a feature any aircraft can have.** Aircraft have fixed geometry. Their wings, fuselage, and engines are sized for specific weights. Pushpak's ability to hold one person or thousands without changing physically is, again, magic.
3. **No mechanism is described.** The Vaimanika Shastra, as fake as it is, at least tried to invent a mechanism (mercury engines). The actual Ramayana does not even attempt one. Pushpak just flies because it is a divine object.
4. **The same text has talking monkeys, ten headed kings, and a sea bridge built by an army of bears.** Do we also claim these prove the existence of intelligent primates, polycephalous humans, and ursine engineering? No. We accept they are part of an epic. The vimana is the same kind of element.

This is the cherry pick trick (Trick 03 from Part 1). The bhakt grabs the one element of the Ramayana that sounds vaguely technological and treats it as fact. The talking monkeys are quietly ignored.

The Honest Picture

The Ramayana is one of the greatest works of literature in human history. Its themes of duty, family, exile, war, and reconciliation have shaped Indian culture for over two thousand years. It deserves to be read, studied, performed, and loved. As literature.

Treating it as an engineering manual **insults** the Ramayana. It reduces a profound epic to a list of half remembered tech specifications. It tells the world that we, modern Indians, cannot appreciate our own scripture for its actual value.

Imagine reading *The Iliad* and concluding that the Greeks must have had nuclear weapons because Zeus's thunderbolts are very powerful. Greeks would find this embarrassing. The actual Greek achievement was the *Iliad* as literature, plus genuine Greek science and philosophy. The same logic applies to India.

Test Yourself

1. By what mechanism does Pushpak supposedly fly, according to the Ramayana?
2. Name one other "supernatural" feature of Pushpak that no real aircraft can replicate.
3. Why is treating Pushpak as engineering actually an insult to the Ramayana?

CHAPTER 03

Ravana's 24 Aircraft and the Airports of Lanka

> The Claim Ravana, the king of Lanka, owned 24 different types of vimanas. He had multiple airports across Sri Lanka. The Weragantota, Thotupola, and Gurulupotha sites in Sri Lanka are the actual ancient airports.

Where It Came From

This is a relatively new claim. The "24 vimanas" specifically were mentioned by **G. Nageshwar Rao**, the Vice Chancellor of Andhra University, at the **106th Indian Science Congress** in January 2019, held at Lovely Professional University in Jalandhar. He stated this from a stage, in front of real scientists, with cameras rolling.

The "Sri Lankan airport" claim has been floating around Indian and Sri Lankan tourism sites for about two decades. It is heavily promoted by certain Buddhist tour operators who sell "Ravana Trail" tours in Sri Lanka. The Sri Lankan Civil Aviation Authority has even named a few historical sites as "Ravana's airports." Yes, really.

What the Original Text Actually Says

Nothing. There is no reference to 24 vimanas anywhere in any version of the Ramayana.

The Valmiki Ramayana mentions Ravana possessing the Pushpak Vimana (one) which he had taken from Kubera. The text does not enumerate other vimanas owned by Ravana. The claim of 24 is invented. It does not appear in the original. It does not appear in any commentary tradition. It does not appear in any of the regional retellings (Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas*, Kamban's Tamil *Iramavataram*, Krittibas's Bengali *Ramayan*).

This is a modern fabrication. Period.

As for the Sri Lankan "airports", here is what the sites actually are.

- **Weragantota** is a small village in central Sri Lanka. There are no aviation related ruins there. There are no runways, no hangars, no fuel storage areas. There is a name that has been creatively interpreted to mean "place where aircraft landed", but the Sinhala word origin is contested and the site is archaeologically just a regular early historic settlement.
- **Thotupola Kanda** is a mountain. It is one of the high peaks of the Horton Plains national park. It has been called "place where aircraft touched down" by tour operators, but it is a mountain. There is no flat area suitable for landing. The name *thotupola* in Sinhala refers to a ferry crossing, not aviation.
- **Gurulupotha** is a village in the Knuckles range. Tour operators describe it as "place of birds" or "aircraft hangar." Archaeologically, it is a forest village.

The Real Science

> **DEFINE: WHAT AN ACTUAL AIRPORT REQUIRES** A working airport needs a **runway** long enough for aircraft to accelerate to take off speed (at minimum a few hundred meters for small aircraft, kilometres for larger). It needs **fuel storage**, since aircraft cannot fly without fuel. It needs **aircraft hangars** for maintenance. It needs **navigation infrastructure**, originally fires and flags, later radio beacons. And it needs roads connecting it to nearby population centres. None of this is found at any of the proposed "Ravana airport" sites.

The earliest known airfields anywhere in the world date to roughly 1910 CE (College Park Airport in Maryland, USA, started 1909). Before powered flight, there were balloon launch sites and glider hills, but these required no infrastructure beyond a hilltop.

The Debunk

1. **The "24 vimanas" number is invented.** No ancient text gives this number. The Vice Chancellor of Andhra University either made it up or borrowed it from someone who made it up.
2. **The "Sri Lankan airports" claim has zero archaeological backing.** The Department of Archaeology of Sri Lanka has never confirmed any aviation site. The "Ravana Trail" tour package is a tourism product, not a historical finding.
3. **If real airports had existed, we would have found them.** Sri Lanka has one of the best documented archaeological landscapes in South Asia, including the world heritage sites of Anuradhapura, Polonnaruwa, and Sigiriya. Two thousand years of digging. No aviation infrastructure has come up. Not a runway, not a hangar, not a fuel depot, not so much as a single wrench.
4. **Compare to confirmed sites.** Anuradhapura has had ten centuries of careful excavation, revealing palaces, monasteries, irrigation tanks, and an entire urban grid. If aviation had existed, we would see at least one component. We see none.

The Honest Picture

Sri Lanka does have a remarkable ancient civilization. The Anuradhapura kingdom (377 BCE to 1017 CE) built sophisticated reservoirs and irrigation systems that are still studied by hydraulic engineers today. The Sigiriya rock fortress (5th century CE) is one of the most stunning archaeological sites in Asia, with frescoes, water gardens, and a five hundred metre tall rock palace. The Anuradhapura stupas were the largest brick structures in the ancient world.

None of this needs Ravana's airports. None of this needs 24 imaginary vimanas. Ancient Lankan civilisation is impressive on its own terms.

Test Yourself

1. Who first claimed the "24 vimanas" number, and where?
2. What four things would a real airport require that the "Sri Lankan airports" lack?
3. Name one real archaeological achievement of ancient Sri Lanka.

CHAPTER 04

Shivkar Bāpuji Talpade and the "1895 Flight"

> The Claim Shivkar Bāpuji Talpade, a Marathi Sanskrit scholar, built and flew an unmanned aircraft called the "Marutsakha" in 1895 from Chowpatty beach in Bombay. This was 8 years before the Wright Brothers. The aircraft flew to 1,500 feet using mercury based propulsion derived from the Vaimanika Shastra. The British stole his design.

Where It Came From

Shivkar Talpade (1864 to 1916) was a real person. He lived in Bombay. He worked at the Sir J.J. School of Art. He was interested in Sanskrit texts on flight. None of that is disputed.

What is disputed is whether anything actually flew in 1895.

Here is the trail of evidence. **There are no contemporary newspaper reports.** No Bombay newspaper of 1895, 1896, or 1897 mentions a Marathi inventor flying an aircraft from Chowpatty beach. This is striking, because the press of that era covered scientific demonstrations heavily. A flying machine, especially one built by an Indian, would have been front page news. There is nothing.

The story comes from later sources, mostly the 1950s onwards. The main early reference is a 1952 book by **P.K. Velkar**, written in Marathi, recounting the story based on alleged eyewitness accounts. Velkar was a great grandnephew of Talpade. He was writing more than half a century after the supposed event, based on family lore.

Later versions, including the heavily promoted 2012 Marathi book *Hawaai* by Pratap Velkar (a different Velkar), added more colourful details. The aircraft flew to 1,500 feet. It was witnessed by Maharaja Sayajirao Gaekwad of Baroda. It crashed and damaged the engine. The British attempted to buy the technology. None of these details appear in any contemporary 1895 source.

What the "Original Text" Actually Says

There is no original text from 1895. There is no surviving aircraft. There are no surviving blueprints. There are no contemporary diary entries from Talpade himself. There are no contemporary letters discussing the flight. The British India Office records, which are extensive for this period, contain no reference to a Talpade aircraft demonstration.

What we have is family memory recorded fifty plus years later, plus speculation. That is the entire evidence base.

The Real Science

The first widely accepted manned, powered, controlled, sustained, heavier than air flight was the Wright brothers' Flyer at Kitty Hawk, North Carolina, on **17 December 1903**. The flight covered 120 feet in 12 seconds. The Wrights had spent years studying aerodynamics, building wind tunnels, testing wing shapes, and developing engine and control systems. They published their work. Their aircraft is in the Smithsonian.

Before the Wrights, there were unmanned and uncontrolled flights. George Cayley flew a glider with a small boy on board in 1853. Otto Lilienthal made thousands of glider flights from 1891 to 1896 (he died testing one). Clément Ader's Avion III may have hopped briefly in 1897 in France. These are all documented in contemporary sources.

For the Talpade claim to be credible, we would need at minimum:

- One contemporary newspaper report.
- One letter, diary entry, or photograph from 1895 or 1896.

- A surviving piece of the aircraft.
- A blueprint or design document.
- A contemporary technical analysis by anyone, friend or foe.

We have none of these.

The Debunk

1. **The aircraft was supposedly based on the Vaimanika Shastra.** Which, as we showed in Chapter 1, was dictated between 1900 and 1922. If Talpade built his plane in 1895, he could not have used a text that was written down five years later. The dates do not work.
2. **Mercury vortex engines do not work.** This is the propulsion system supposedly used. As the 1974 IISc study showed, you cannot get thrust from mercury sloshing in pots. The chemistry does not allow it. Mercury at the scale Talpade would have used would also have been extremely heavy and poisonous.
3. **No contemporary documentation exists.** We have already covered this. Family memory written 50+ years later is not evidence.
4. **The "British stole his design" claim is a stretch.** The Wright brothers' work is fully documented. They corresponded with Octave Chanute and Samuel Langley. They studied Lilienthal. They did not visit Bombay, did not receive correspondence from Talpade, and did not need to. Their design uses an aerofoil, a gasoline engine, and three axis control. Nothing about Talpade's supposed aircraft resembles this.

The Honest Picture

Talpade was a sincere Sanskrit scholar interested in old texts. He probably did experiment with model aircraft. Several Indians did similar work in the late 1800s. But there is no evidence he beat the Wright brothers, or even that he flew a sustained powered model.

The real Indian aviation pioneer most people have never heard of is **J.R.D. Tata**, who flew India's first commercial flight in **October 1932**. Tata's pilot license is number one in India. He started Tata Airlines, which became Air India. He personally flew flights into the 1980s. *That* is documented Indian aviation history. With photographs, newspaper articles, surviving aircraft, and witnesses who lived into our times.

If Talpade actually flew an aircraft in 1895, we would all be celebrating him with statues and museums. We don't, because the evidence isn't there.

Test Yourself

1. When was the Vaimanika Shastra actually dictated, and why does this create a problem for the Talpade story?
2. What contemporary 1895 evidence exists for Talpade's flight?
3. Name a documented Indian aviation pioneer with real evidence.

CHAPTER 05

Interplanetary Travel. Trips to Other Worlds

> The Claim Ancient Indians travelled to other planets. The Puranas describe seven upper worlds (lokas) and seven lower worlds, with detailed accounts of journeys between them. Krishna travelled to Vaikuntha. Arjuna travelled to Indraloka. These were physical interplanetary journeys, not metaphors.

Where It Came From

This claim appears in many forms. The most common is in political speeches and WhatsApp forwards that conflate "loka" with "planet." The framing is usually: "look, the Puranas mention multiple worlds, so we obviously knew about space travel."

The Puranas are a body of Sanskrit texts compiled mostly between 300 and 1500 CE, though they draw on much older oral traditions. They describe cosmology in detail. The cosmology is real Hindu cosmology. The question is whether it has anything to do with modern astronomy.

What the Original Text Actually Says

The Puranic cosmology, fully laid out in texts like the *Vishnu Purana*, *Bhagavata Purana*, and *Surya Siddhanta*, describes a layered universe.

- The Earth is depicted as a flat disc with seven concentric continents separated by oceans of milk, ghee, wine, and other substances.
- The centre is Mount Meru, a mythical mountain.
- Above the Earth are seven upper worlds. Bhurloka, Bhuvarloka, Svarloka, Maharloka, Janaloka, Tapoloka, and Satyaloka. These are spiritual realms inhabited by gods and elevated beings.
- Below the Earth are seven lower worlds, the talas, inhabited by demons and snakes.
- Vaikuntha, Vishnu's abode, is beyond all of these, in a non material realm.

This is a beautiful cosmological model. It is also **fundamentally not astronomical**. There is no Earth orbiting the sun, no other planets in our solar system, no galaxies, no light years. The "worlds" are metaphysical layers, not physical bodies.

Wendy Doniger, in her translations of the Bhagavata Purana, makes this explicit. The lokas are categorized by spiritual quality, not physical location.

The Real Science

DEFINE: A PLANET A planet, in modern astronomy, is a body that orbits a star, has enough mass to be roughly spherical from its own gravity, and has cleared its orbit of other large bodies. Our solar system has eight planets. None of them are "worlds inhabited by gods" or "realms of demons." All of them have been physically observed, photographed, and in many cases visited by robotic spacecraft.

The first artificial object to leave Earth was Sputnik 1, launched by the Soviet Union in October 1957. The first human in space was Yuri Gagarin, in April 1961. The first human on the Moon was Neil Armstrong, in July 1969. The first robotic mission to Mars to land successfully was Viking 1, in 1976. No human has ever been to Mars, Venus, Mercury, or any other planet. India sent the Mangalyaan orbiter to Mars in 2014, becoming the fourth space agency to reach Mars (after NASA, the Soviet Union, and the European Space Agency).

The Debunk

1. **Lokas are not planets.** They are spiritual or metaphysical realms. Even traditional Hindu philosophers like Adi Shankara treated them as states of consciousness or planes of being, not as physical objects orbiting the sun.
2. **Puranic cosmology contradicts modern astronomy in the most basic ways.** A flat Earth with seven concentric continents on milk and ghee oceans is not a description of our actual planet. If you take Puranic cosmology literally, you have to also believe in those oceans. If you don't, you've already admitted it is symbolic.
3. **"Travelling to lokas" in the texts uses magical means.** Sages travel by yogic power, by divine permission, by special vehicles like Pushpak. None of these are described as engineered spacecraft. The texts give no physical mechanism. Compare to actual spaceflight, which requires rocket engines, escape velocity calculations, life support, and orbital mechanics, all spelled out in detail.
4. **If ancient Indians had physical interplanetary travel, where is the evidence?** No spacecraft remains. No launch facilities. No descriptions of weightlessness, vacuum, radiation, or temperature extremes, all of which any real space traveller would experience and remember. The Puranas describe lokas as inhabited, breathable, sunlit places, which actual planets in our solar system are not.

The Honest Picture

India is genuinely a major space power. Not a "we figured it out in the Puranas" space power, an actual modern space power.

- **1969.** ISRO is founded by Vikram Sarabhai. India launches its first sounding rockets.
- **1975.** Aryabhata, India's first satellite, is launched.
- **1980.** SLV-3 successfully launches Rohini from Indian soil, making India the seventh country to develop independent satellite launch capability.
- **2008.** Chandrayaan 1 orbits the Moon and discovers water molecules on the lunar surface, a finding confirmed by NASA's M3 instrument aboard the probe.
- **2014.** Mangalyaan reaches Mars orbit on its first attempt and at one tenth the cost of NASA's MAVEN mission, which arrived two days later.
- **2023.** Chandrayaan 3 lands near the south pole of the Moon, the first nation to achieve this.
- **2023.** Aditya L1 reaches the L1 Lagrange point to study the Sun.
- **2026 (planned).** Gaganyaan, India's first crewed space mission.

This is real, documented, modern Indian space achievement. It is at this point one of the most impressive space programmes in the world by results per rupee spent. None of it required the Puranas to be literal interplanetary travel logs. ISRO scientists are not standing on the Vaimanika Shastra. They are standing on Newtonian mechanics, rocket equations, and decades of hard engineering.

Test Yourself

1. What is the basic difference between a "loka" in Puranic cosmology and a "planet" in modern astronomy?
2. Which two real Indian space missions reached the Moon and Mars?
3. If ancient Indians had real space travel, what physical evidence would we expect to find?

CHAPTER 06

Sanjay's Divya Drishti. The "Mahabharata Internet"

> The Claim In the Mahabharata, Sanjay narrates the Kurukshetra war to the blind king Dhritarashtra in real time, describing battles happening hundreds of kilometres away. This proves ancient India had the internet, live video streaming, or some equivalent technology.

Where It Came From

The Sanjay narrative is from the **Bhishma Parva** of the Mahabharata, one of the largest sections of the epic. It is genuinely ancient. The Mahabharata in its current form was compiled between roughly 400 BCE and 400 CE, though it draws on much older oral traditions.

The "Sanjay equals internet" claim is modern. It became popular in the 2000s and is now a stock claim in political speeches and WhatsApp forwards.

What the Original Text Actually Says

The setup is this. King Dhritarashtra is blind. His sons, the Kauravas, are about to fight his nephews, the Pandavas, in the great war at Kurukshetra. The king wants to know what is happening on the battlefield, but he cannot see it himself.

The sage **Vyasa**, who authored the Mahabharata in the story's own internal logic, grants **Sanjay**, Dhritarashtra's minister and charioteer, a special power called **divya drishti**. Divine sight. Sanjay can now see everything happening on the battlefield, hear every conversation, even read every thought, from his seat in the palace far from Kurukshetra.

The text is explicit. **This is a magical gift from Vyasa.** It is not a device. It is not equipment. It is not transmitted via any medium. Sanjay does not point a dish at the sky. He does not put on headphones. He sits in the palace and his mind perceives the battle directly, by Vyasa's blessing.

> *"And Vyasa said: O Sanjaya, I confer upon thee the eye divine, so that thou mayest behold the battle with thy own eyes. Free from fatigue, free from injury, thou shalt know all that happens, in heart and in body." Mahabharata, Bhishma Parva, Section 2. Bibek Debroy's English translation (Penguin, Volume 4, 2011), based on the BORI Critical Edition.*

The Real Science

> **DEFINE: HOW THE INTERNET ACTUALLY WORKS** The internet is a network of physical computers connected by wires (fibre optic cables), wireless signals (Wi-Fi, cellular), and undersea cables. Data is broken into packets, each packet is given an address, packets are routed through multiple servers using protocols (TCP/IP). At the destination, packets are reassembled into the original information. This requires electricity, semiconductors, fibre optics, radio transmitters, routers, and a globally coordinated protocol. None of these existed in ancient India. Or anywhere, before the late 20th century.

The first networked computers communicated in 1969, on ARPANET. The first email was sent in 1971. The World Wide Web was created by Tim Berners-Lee in 1989. Live video streaming at scale became practical in the late 1990s. None of these depend on "divine sight."

The Debunk

1. **Divine sight is magic. The internet is not magic.** If Sanjay's ability counts as "internet", then every clairvoyance story in every religion counts as internet. Christian saints had visions of

distant events. Sufi mystics described battles in far cities. Greek oracles spoke of events they could not have witnessed. By the bhakt's logic, all of these are also "ancient internet." They are not. They are religious narratives about supernatural perception.

2. **The Mahabharata text describes no equipment, no medium, no signal.** Sanjay does not turn on a device. He does not face any direction. He does not require power or connection. He just sits and his consciousness sees. This is the opposite of a technological description.
3. **The "internet" framing comes from the Mahabharata being a popular story, not from any technical analysis.** If you asked a network engineer to look at the Sanjay narrative and identify the internet, they would laugh. There is nothing in it that corresponds to network architecture.
4. **Sanjay also perceives thoughts and emotions.** No version of the internet does this. Mind reading is not a feature. If the bhakt wants to say "Sanjay is like the internet", they then have to explain why our internet cannot read minds. The answer, obviously, is that Sanjay's gift is magical and not analogous to any real technology.

The Honest Picture

India is a real technology superpower. Not because of Sanjay. Because of decades of hard work by Indian engineers, mathematicians, and entrepreneurs.

- **1981.** Infosys founded. Wipro turning into a tech company. Tata Consultancy Services already established.
- **1991 to present.** Bangalore becomes a global tech hub. Hyderabad, Pune, Chennai follow.
- **2016.** India launches UPI, the Unified Payments Interface. By 2024, UPI processes over 100 billion transactions per year, more digital payments by volume than any other country in the world.
- **2024.** India's IT services exports cross $200 billion annually.
- **Today.** Indian engineers run a significant share of Silicon Valley's senior technical leadership. Sundar Pichai (Google), Satya Nadella (Microsoft), Shantanu Narayen (Adobe), Parag Agrawal (former Twitter), Arvind Krishna (IBM), and many more.

These are real Indian technological achievements. They beat the Vaimanika Shastra and Sanjay's divya drishti combined, by every measure that matters. Indians today actually move billions of dollars and billions of messages around the world every day. They do not do it by sitting in a palace and concentrating.

Test Yourself

1. Where in the Mahabharata is Sanjay's divine sight introduced, and by whom is it granted?
2. Name three things the actual internet requires that Sanjay's "divya drishti" does not.
3. What modern Indian technology achievement is more impressive than the Sanjay story?

CHAPTER 07

Television in the Mahabharata

> The Claim The Mahabharata describes television. Sanjay narrating the war was a TV broadcast. Krishna showing the universe inside his mouth to his foster mother Yashoda was a holographic display. Therefore television, holography, and broadcast media all existed in ancient India.

Where It Came From

This is a variation on the Sanjay claim from the previous chapter. Some bhakts say "internet." Some say "television." A few say "satellite TV" or even "VR headset." The fact that the same scene gets repurposed as evidence for different modern technologies is itself the giveaway. If Sanjay's divine sight is "really" any of these things, it cannot be all of them.

The Krishna and Yashoda scene comes from the **Bhagavata Purana**, Book 10. The child Krishna is accused of eating mud. His mother Yashoda asks him to open his mouth. When he does, she sees the entire universe inside it.

What the Original Text Actually Says

For Sanjay, we already covered the text in Chapter 6. He receives divya drishti as a divine gift from Vyasa. No device.

For Krishna and Yashoda, here is the actual scene from the Bhagavata Purana.

> *"When the boy opened his mouth, Yashoda saw within it the whole universe. The earth, the sky, the directions, the stars, the wind, the fire, the oceans, the continents, the mountains, herself, the village, and her own self standing there, holding the boy." Bhagavata Purana, Book 10, Canto 8, verse 37. Translation by Edwin Bryant, Penguin Classics (2003).*

This is one of the most famous mystical visions in Hindu literature. It is a moment of **theological revelation**, where the limited human mother sees that her son is, in truth, the universe itself. It is a poem about the divine within the everyday. It is not a description of a hologram, a TV, or a VR experience.

The Real Science

DEFINE: HOW TELEVISION ACTUALLY WORKS Television converts moving images and sound into electrical signals, transmits them via radio waves or cables, and reconstructs the images on a screen at the receiving end. The screen uses electron beams (old CRT TVs), liquid crystals (LCDs), or organic light emitting diodes (OLEDs) to recreate the picture pixel by pixel. None of this is possible without electricity, semiconductors, and broadcasting infrastructure.

Television was invented in stages. **John Logie Baird** demonstrated the first mechanical television in London in 1925. **Philo Farnsworth** demonstrated the first all electronic television in San Francisco in 1927. The first regular broadcast TV service started in 1929 in Germany. Colour TV became widespread in the 1960s. Holography (real holography, not movie holograms) was developed by Dennis Gabor in 1947, who won the Nobel Prize for it in 1971. None of these technologies existed before the 20th century, anywhere on Earth.

The Debunk

1. **The same scene cannot be evidence for multiple unrelated technologies.** Sanjay's divya drishti is variously claimed as internet, TV, satellite, video call, and live broadcast, depending on which bhakt is talking. If it were any one of these, it could not also be the others. This

inconsistency itself is the tell. The bhakt is matching a story to whatever modern thing they want to claim ownership of. Trick 02 from Part 1, reading backwards.

2. **Krishna's mouth is not a hologram.** It is a theophany. In religious literature, a theophany is when the divine shows itself to a mortal in a way that overwhelms ordinary perception. Moses sees a burning bush. Arjuna sees Krishna's universal form. Yashoda sees the universe in her son's mouth. None of these scenes are describing display technology. They are describing direct divine experience.
3. **Yashoda is the only viewer.** A real TV broadcast has many simultaneous viewers receiving the same signal. The universe in Krishna's mouth is shown to one woman, who is then made to forget it. This is the opposite of broadcasting.
4. **There is no transmission.** No radio waves, no electricity, no fibre, no transmission tower. The vision happens because Krishna wills it. That is, again, magic, not media technology.

The Honest Picture

India has a real television and media history that is worth knowing.

- **1959.** Doordarshan begins experimental broadcasts from Delhi. India is one of the earlier countries in Asia to start a national TV service.
- **1975 to 1976.** SITE, the Satellite Instructional Television Experiment, broadcasts educational content to 2,400 rural Indian villages, using the American ATS-6 satellite. This was a pioneering use of satellite TV for rural education, studied and admired worldwide.
- **1982.** Doordarshan begins colour broadcasting, coinciding with the Asian Games in Delhi.
- **1991 onward.** Liberalisation opens up Indian television to private and satellite channels. Star TV, Zee TV, and others transform the media landscape.
- **2010s onward.** India becomes one of the world's largest markets for streaming services, with Netflix, Amazon Prime, Hotstar, and JioCinema together serving hundreds of millions of viewers.
- **Indian film industry.** India produces more films per year than any other country, and the Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada, Marathi, Bengali, and other regional industries together represent one of the world's most diverse cinematic traditions.

These are real achievements. They are documented. They built on the actual physics of television and broadcasting. They did not need the Mahabharata to be a manual.

Test Yourself

1. What is a theophany, and which two examples did this chapter mention?
2. Name the two inventors who together created modern television in the 1920s.
3. Why is "Krishna's mouth as hologram" inconsistent even with "Sanjay as TV broadcaster"?

CHAPTER 08

Narada Muni. The "Ancient Satellite"

> The Claim The sage Narada Muni travels constantly between worlds, carrying messages between gods. This proves ancient India had satellite communication or wireless technology.

Where It Came From

Narada is a beloved figure in Hindu mythology. He appears in the Vedas, in many Puranas, and in countless folk stories. He is a divine sage, one of the seven manasaputras (mind born sons) of Brahma. He carries a musical instrument, the vina, and travels everywhere, chanting Vishnu's name.

The "Narada equals satellite" claim is recent. It has been pushed especially in the 2010s by political speakers wanting to credit Indian mythology with anticipating ISRO.

What the Original Text Actually Says

Narada's travels are described in many Puranas, especially the **Bhagavata Purana**, the **Narada Purana**, and the **Padma Purana**. The descriptions are remarkably consistent on a few points.

- Narada travels by divine power. He thinks of a destination, he is there. No vehicle. No flight path. No fuel.
- He travels alone. He does not carry equipment.
- He communicates by speaking. Face to face, when he arrives somewhere.
- He sings constantly. The vina is for music, not communication.
- He can visit any loka, including Vaikuntha (Vishnu's realm) and Patala (the underworld), which are not described as physically navigable spaces.

Narada is a **messenger sage**, in the literary tradition that also produced Hermes in Greek mythology and Iris in Homer. These are characters whose job is to carry information between divine and mortal realms. They are not technology.

The Real Science

DEFINE: HOW SATELLITES ACTUALLY WORK A satellite is a physical object placed in orbit around the Earth (or another body). It carries radio transmitters and receivers. Signals from the ground reach the satellite, the satellite either amplifies them and sends them back (relay), or processes them (transponders), and sends the output back to other ground stations. Satellites need rocket launches to reach orbit, solar panels for power, and precise station keeping to stay in their orbit. The first communication satellite, Telstar 1, was launched in 1962. India's first communication satellite, APPLE, was launched in 1981.

For satellite communication to count as "in the Puranas", you would need the text to describe at least one of: orbit, radio transmission, signal modulation, energy source, or relay function. The Puranas describe none of these.

The Debunk

1. **A traveller is not a satellite.** A messenger who walks from city to city is not a postal network. A monk who delivers letters is not email. A divine sage who teleports between realms is not a communication satellite. Same logical error.
2. **Narada does not relay signals.** A satellite receives signals from one location and rebroadcasts them to another. Narada actually has to be physically present in both places. He carries information by going there himself, not by transmitting through a medium.

3. **Narada visits realms that are not in physical space.** Vaikuntha is not in our solar system. Patala is not under the ground in a way that any geological survey could find. These are metaphysical destinations. A satellite, by definition, has a physical orbital position.
4. **The texts make no claim to be technological.** The Puranas describe Narada as a divine sage with divine powers. They do not say "and this divine power is exactly like a future invention humans will make in 1962 CE." This bridge is being built by the bhakt, not by the text.

The Honest Picture

India is one of the world's leading satellite nations. As of 2026, ISRO has launched well over 100 Indian satellites and assisted in launching over 400 foreign satellites for paying customers. Some highlights.

- **1975.** Aryabhata, India's first satellite, launched on a Soviet rocket.
- **1981.** APPLE, India's first communication satellite.
- **1983 to present.** The INSAT series, India's communication and weather satellites, providing TV, telephone, and weather services across the country.
- **1988 onward.** The IRS series, India's remote sensing satellites, used worldwide for agriculture, forestry, urban planning, and disaster management.
- **2017.** ISRO launches 104 satellites in a single mission on the PSLV-C37, a world record at the time.
- **Continuing.** The GSLV launches geosynchronous satellites for communication. The NavIC system provides Indian regional satellite navigation, similar to GPS.

These are real Indian satellites in real orbits doing real work. The engineers at ISRO are the genuine modern Naradas, if you want to use that comparison. They actually move information across the subcontinent every minute of every day.

Test Yourself

1. By what means does Narada travel between worlds, according to the Puranas?
2. Name two things a real communication satellite requires that Narada does not have.
3. What was India's first satellite, and when was it launched?

CHAPTER 09

Robots and Mechanical Guards

> The Claim Ancient Indian texts describe robots. The *Lokapannatti* tells of mechanical warriors guarding Buddha's relics. The *Samarangana Sutradhara* describes mechanical men, flying birds, and automatic vehicles. This proves robotics existed in ancient India, thousands of years before the modern field.

Where It Came From

The two texts cited are real, though their dates and contents need careful unpacking.

The **Lokapannatti** is a Burmese Pali Buddhist text, traditionally dated to around the 11th or 12th century CE. It tells stories that draw on older Buddhist traditions but were compiled relatively late. The Lokapannatti contains a famous story about the emperor Ashoka and "mechanical warriors" (yantakara) built by craftsmen from Roman lands (called "Yavana") to guard the relics of the Buddha.

The **Samarangana Sutradhara** is a Sanskrit text on architecture and engineering attributed to King Bhoja of Dhar, an 11th century CE Paramara dynasty king. It is genuinely interesting. It contains chapters on architecture, town planning, and yes, a chapter on mechanical devices (yantras).

Neither text is from "ancient" India in the way the claim suggests. Both are medieval. The 11th century CE is closer to William the Conqueror than to the supposed Vedic golden age.

What the Original Text Actually Says

The Lokapannatti story is a folk legend. It says that emperor Ashoka wanted to protect Buddha's relics, so he had Yavana craftsmen build mechanical warriors. The mechanism is not described in detail. The warriors are said to swing swords at intruders. They are eventually disabled by a man named Bhuta who steals the relics by tricking them.

This is a story. It is not engineering documentation. It does not describe gears, pulleys, energy sources, or sensors. The Lokapannatti tells us what the warriors do (swing swords), not how they work. It is in the same category as the Greek myth of Talos, the bronze giant who guarded Crete, or the Jewish folklore of the Golem of Prague.

The Samarangana Sutradhara is more interesting. Chapter 31 of the text does discuss mechanical devices, including:

- Mechanical wooden men that move using strings and gears.
- Mechanical wooden birds.
- A flying machine powered by, again, mercury.
- Various clocks and water lifts.

Some of these (the clocks, water lifts, and string operated puppets) are plausible. Mechanical puppets have existed in many cultures. The flying machine is the same kind of fanciful description as the Vaimanika Shastra and does not actually work as described.

The Real Science

DEFINE: A ROBOT A robot, in the modern sense, is a programmable machine that can sense its environment and act on it. The word "robot" was coined by Czech writer Karel Čapek in 1920. The first industrial robot, Unimate, was installed at a General Motors plant in 1961. Modern robots use motors, sensors, microprocessors, software, and often AI. They are programmable, which means their behaviour can be changed without rebuilding them. None of the medieval Indian devices have this property. They were single purpose mechanical curiosities.

The Debunk

1. **Mechanical curiosities are not robots.** The ancient and medieval world produced many impressive mechanical devices. Hero of Alexandria built steam toys in the first century CE. Chinese inventors built mechanical orchestras. Al-Jazari in 12th century Iraq designed elaborate water clocks with moving figures. Leonardo da Vinci drew mechanical knights in the 15th century. These are all in the same category as the Indian devices. None of them are robots. They are clever mechanisms.
2. **The Lokapannatti mechanical warriors are explicitly built by "Yavana" craftsmen.** Yavana means Greek or Roman. The story itself attributes the technology to imported foreign expertise. If the bhakt wants to use this as evidence of indigenous Indian robotics, they are arguing against their own source.
3. **The Samarangana Sutradhara is medieval, not ancient.** King Bhoja ruled in the 11th century CE. The claim "this proves ancient Indian robotics" is incorrect on the date alone.
4. **Single purpose machines are not robots.** A puppet that bows when you pull a string is a puppet. A self winding water clock is a water clock. Neither senses its environment or makes decisions. They execute a single mechanical action.

The Honest Picture

Ancient and medieval India did have a real tradition of mechanical engineering. The Samarangana Sutradhara is a genuine and impressive text, despite the imaginary flying machine. Indian temple architecture used sophisticated mechanical principles. The temple cars (chariots) at places like Puri and Madurai have mechanisms for moving enormous weights. Indian water management systems, especially in Rajasthan and the south, used sophisticated mechanical lifts and dams.

Modern India has world class robotics research. The IITs, IISc, and many private institutes produce researchers who work at top robotics labs worldwide. Indian software powers significant portions of modern robotics and AI. Indian startups in autonomous vehicles, drones, and industrial automation are growing rapidly.

The achievement is real. It is happening right now. It does not require us to pretend that an 11th century puppet was a Honda ASIMO.

Test Yourself

1. What is the actual date of the Samarangana Sutradhara, and why does this complicate the "ancient robotics" claim?
2. Who built the mechanical warriors in the Lokapannatti, according to the text itself?
3. What is the modern definition of a robot, and how does it differ from a mechanical puppet?

CHAPTER 10

Self Driving Chariots and Ancient AI

> The Claim Ancient Indian texts describe self driving chariots, vehicles that move on their own without a human driver. The Mahabharata and the Puranas describe many such vehicles. This proves ancient India had artificial intelligence and autonomous vehicles.

Where It Came From

This is one of the newer claims, popping up in WhatsApp forwards and political speeches mostly after 2010, when self driving cars became a hot topic globally.

The claim usually points to one of three texts. The Mahabharata's mention of various divine chariots. The Puranas' descriptions of vehicles used by the gods. Or the Samarangana Sutradhara from the previous chapter, which mentioned mechanical contraptions.

What the Original Text Actually Says

Let us look at the actual descriptions of "self driving" vehicles in the relevant texts.

The Mahabharata. Krishna is described as an extraordinarily skilled charioteer who drives Arjuna's chariot during the Kurukshetra war. The chariot does not drive itself. Krishna drives it. The Bhagavad Gita, which takes place on Arjuna's chariot, makes this explicit. Krishna holds the reins. The horses, named Saibya, Sugriva, Meghapushpa, and Balahaka, do the pulling.

This is the exact opposite of a self driving vehicle. The Gita is essentially a long conversation between the human passenger (Arjuna) and the driver (Krishna). If Krishna's chariot drove itself, there would be no Gita.

The Pushpak Vimana. We covered this in Chapter 2. Pushpak moves by the will of the owner. Some bhakts cite this as "self driving." But "moves by will of owner" is not the same as "drives itself." A self driving car has its own decision making (powered by AI software). Pushpak has zero decision making. It does exactly what the owner wills. If anything, it is the most overcontrolled vehicle in literature.

Divine chariots in the Puranas. Surya's chariot is driven by Aruna. Indra's vehicle is the elephant Airavata. Various gods have various vehicles, all of which are either driven by another being or pulled by animals. None of them are autonomous in any sense relevant to modern AI.

The Real Science

> **DEFINE: HOW A SELF DRIVING CAR ACTUALLY WORKS** A self driving car needs three things. First, **sensing**. The car uses cameras, LIDAR (laser based distance sensors), radar, and GPS to perceive its surroundings. Second, **decision making**. Software, increasingly using machine learning, analyses the sensor data and decides what to do (brake, turn, accelerate). Third, **actuation**. Motors, hydraulics, and electronic controls execute the decisions on the vehicle's steering, throttle, and brakes. The first prototype self driving cars appeared in the 1980s (Carnegie Mellon's Navlab, Mercedes-Benz's VaMP). The first commercially deployed autonomous vehicles came in the 2010s.

The Debunk

1. **"Driven by Krishna" is the opposite of "self driving."** The whole point of the Bhagavad Gita scene is that Arjuna has an expert charioteer (who is also God) handling the driving. Citing this as evidence of self driving cars is reading the text in the exact opposite direction of what it says.

2. **"Moves by will of the owner" is also not self driving.** A self driving car makes its own decisions based on sensors and software. A vehicle that does whatever the owner thinks is, by definition, controlled by the owner. The owner is just controlling it without a steering wheel. It is still not autonomous.
3. **No text describes the three components of autonomy.** Sensing, decision making, actuation. None of the Indian texts mention anything resembling cameras, lasers, AI, or feedback control. The Vaimanika Shastra, as we showed in Chapter 1, mostly describes mercury sloshing in pots, not control systems.
4. **The pattern is now familiar.** A modern technology becomes famous. Bhakts go back through old texts looking for anything vaguely similar. They find a chariot. They claim it is the new thing. We have seen this pattern with airplanes, internet, TV, satellites, and now self driving cars. It is Trick 02 from Part 1, retrofitting. The "discovery" only ever happens after the modern invention.

The Honest Picture

India is actively working on autonomous vehicles. As of 2026, several Indian startups, IIT research labs, and Indian arms of global companies are developing self driving technology suited for Indian roads, which are famously chaotic and challenging. Indian engineers are leading AI teams at companies like Google, Microsoft, Tesla, and OpenAI.

Indian software engineers and computer scientists are at the cutting edge of artificial intelligence. The director of Google DeepMind's India operations, the chief scientist of multiple top tier AI labs, the founders of major AI startups, are all Indians or of Indian origin.

This is the real Indian contribution to autonomy and AI. It is happening this decade. It does not require a chariot driven by Krishna to be evidence of anything other than excellent storytelling. The Bhagavad Gita is among the greatest philosophical texts in human history. That is its actual value. It does not need to also be an SAE Level 5 autonomous vehicle manual to be important.

Test Yourself

1. Who actually drives Arjuna's chariot in the Mahabharata, and how does this contradict the "self driving" claim?
2. What are the three components a real self driving car requires?
3. Which "Trick" from Part 1 is most clearly being used in claims that the Bhagavad Gita describes autonomous vehicles?

END OF PART 2

What You Just Learned and Sources

What You Just Learned

- The **Vaimanika Shastra** is a 1900 to 1922 CE trance dictation, not an ancient text. Five IISc engineers showed in 1974 that none of its aircraft can fly. Almost every other "ancient flying machine" claim sources from this single fake book.
- **Pushpak Vimana** is described in the Ramayana as magical (moves by thought, changes size), not engineered. Treating it as engineering insults the epic.
- **Ravana's "24 vimanas" and "Sri Lankan airports"** are modern fabrications. No ancient text gives the number 24. No archaeological evidence of airports exists.
- **Shivkar Talpade's "1895 flight"** has no contemporary documentation. The story comes from family memory recorded 50 plus years later. Plus, the Vaimanika Shastra he supposedly used had not yet been written.
- **Interplanetary travel.** Puranic "lokas" are spiritual realms, not physical planets. Modern India is a real space power through ISRO.
- **Sanjay's "divya drishti", Krishna's mouth, Narada Muni.** All described in the texts as *magical* gifts or powers, never as devices or technology. Confusing these with internet, TV, or satellites is Trick 02 from Part 1, retrofitting.
- **Mechanical "robots".** Medieval texts describe puppets, water clocks, and the like. Single purpose curiosities, not programmable autonomous machines.
- **Self driving chariots.** Krishna driving Arjuna's chariot is the exact opposite of self driving. The Bhagavad Gita is literally a conversation between the passenger and the driver.

The Pattern

Every claim in this part follows the same shape. A modern technology becomes famous. Someone goes back through old texts. They find a story with a vague similarity. They declare ancient Indian invention. The original text either describes the thing as magical, or describes it as something completely different, or does not describe it at all.

This is the bhakt method. Once you see it, you cannot unsee it. Every future claim you encounter will fit this pattern.

What's Next

Part 3. Weapons and Physics. Brahmastra as nuclear weapon. Mohenjo Daro's "nuclear" destruction. Vishnu Chakra as guided missile. Einstein's $E=mc^2$ supposedly in the Vedas. The speed of light in the Hanuman Chalisa. Gravity discovered before Newton. The atom discovered by Kanada. Ten more chapters. Ten more debunks.

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The strongest argument is the one that can survive a fact check.
Make sure yours always can.

LOVEPREET SINGH